

Psalms 44

For Thy Sake

For thy sake are we killed all the day long
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *We have heard with our ears, O God, our fathers have told us, what work thou didst in their days, in the times of old.*
- 2 *How thou didst drive out the heathen with thy hand, and plantedst them; how thou didst afflict the people, and cast them out.*
- 3 *For they got not the land in possession by their own sword, neither did their own arm save them: but thy right hand, and thine arm, and the light of thy countenance, because thou hadst a favour unto them.*
- 4 *Thou art my King, O God: command deliverances for Jacob.*
- 5 *Through thee will we push down our enemies: through thy name will we tread them under that rise up against us.*
- 6 *For I will not trust in my bow, neither shall my sword save me.*
- 7 *But thou hast saved us from our enemies, and hast put them to shame that hated us.*
- 8 *In God we boast all the day long, and praise thy name for ever. Selah.*
- 9 *But thou hast cast off, and put us to shame; and goest not forth with our armies.*
- 10 *Thou makest us to turn back from the enemy: and they which hate us spoil for themselves.*
- 11 *Thou hast given us like sheep appointed for meat; and hast scattered us among the heathen.*
- 12 *Thou sellest thy people for nought, and dost not increase thy wealth by their price.*
- 13 *Thou makest us a reproach to our neighbours, a scorn and a derision to them that are round about us.*
- 14 *Thou makest us a byword among the heathen, a shaking of the head among the people.*
- 15 *My confusion is continually before me, and the shame of my face hath covered me,*
- 16 *For the voice of him that reproacheth and blasphemeth; by reason of the enemy and avenger.*
- 17 *All this is come upon us; yet have we not forgotten thee, neither have we dealt falsely in thy covenant.*
- 18 *Our heart is not turned back, neither have our steps declined from thy way;*
- 19 *Though thou hast sore broken us in the place of dragons, and covered us with the shadow of death.*
- 20 *If we have forgotten the name of our God, or stretched out our hands to a strange god;*
- 21 *Shall not God search this out? for he knoweth the secrets of the heart.*
- 22 *Yea, for thy sake are we killed all the day long; we are counted as sheep for the slaughter.*
- 23 *Awake, why sleepest thou, O Lord? arise, cast us not off for ever.*
- 24 *Wherefore hidest thou thy face, and forgettest our affliction and our oppression?*
- 25 *For our soul is bowed down to the dust: our belly cleaveth unto the earth.*
- 26 *Arise for our help, and redeem us for thy mercies' sake.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 44 is a national lament that recalls God's mighty past deliverances for the fathers—driving out the nations and planting Israel in the land—set sharply against present defeat and scattering, even though the nation insists it has not forsaken the covenant. Verse 22, “for thy sake are we killed all the day long,” is quoted by Paul in Romans 8:36 regarding suffering endured for Christ's sake. Henry reads it as a model of corporate lament that refuses to explain suffering by pointing to apostasy where none has occurred, appealing instead to God's proven faithfulness and covenant love.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

The people have heard with their own ears what their fathers told them of God's works in driving out the heathen and planting them in the land—accomplished not by their own sword but by God's right hand, arm, and the light of His favor.

Verse 4-8

A declaration of present trust: “Thou art my King”; through God alone they push down enemies, not trusting bow or sword but the God who saves; they boast in God all day and will praise His name forever.

Verse 9-12

Yet now God has seemingly cast them off and put them to shame, no longer going forth with their armies; He has made them turn back so enemies spoil at will, given them like sheep for meat, scattered them among the nations, and sold His people for nothing.

Verse 13-16

They have become a reproach to their neighbors, scorn and derision to those around them, a byword among the nations, met with shaking heads—shame and confusion continually before them because of the reproacher’s voice.

Verse 17-19

Despite all this, they insist they have not forgotten God nor dealt falsely with His covenant; their heart has not turned back nor their steps declined, yet they are sorely broken in a place of jackals, covered with the shadow of death.

Verse 20-22

If they had forgotten God’s name or stretched out their hands to a strange god, would He not search it out, since He knows the secrets of the heart? Instead, for God’s sake they are killed all the day long, counted as sheep for the slaughter.

Verse 23-26

A final urgent cry: Awake, why sleepest Thou, Lord? Cast us not off forever; why hidest Thou Thy face and forgettest our affliction and oppression? Their soul is bowed down to the dust; arise for our help, and redeem us for Thy mercies’ sake.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Not all suffering is punishment for unfaithfulness; sometimes God’s people suffer precisely for His sake while remaining loyal to Him, and the honest response is protest joined to appeal, not silent assumption of guilt. Confusing present hardship for divine rejection is a real temptation that faith must argue against by remembering God’s proven character.

Application for life today.

Resist the reflex to assume suffering always signals hidden sin; sometimes, as Paul applies this psalm, faithful people suffer precisely because of their faithfulness. Bring corporate or communal grief—not just personal grief—honestly to God the way this psalm does for a whole nation. Practice appealing to God’s past faithfulness (vv. 1–3) as leverage for present prayer rather than assuming the past has nothing to do with now.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Have you or people you love suffered “for God’s sake” in a way that had nothing to do with unfaithfulness—and how does this psalm validate that experience?

2. What past evidence of God’s faithfulness (personal or communal) could you use, like verses 1–3, to fuel a present appeal to Him?

3. Where do you need to pray “awake... arise for our help” (vv. 23, 26) about a situation that currently feels like divine silence?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).